



CROSS-COUNTRY FOOTPRINT The entrance to the Zoji-la tunnel (left); MEIL is helping build HPCL's Rajasthan Refinery in Barmer's Pachpadra, which is located in the Thar desert

sorption'. For example, Megha uses infrared technology in the Zoji-la tunnel to record all movements during construction. MEIL's "cylinder bottom box" in its oil rigs, a global first, works on hydraulic force to elevate the mast. "MEIL is known for using cutting-edge technology in its projects," it states. The report cites the shale shaker tank, "an intensive vibrating device used in oil and gas drilling rigs", which sieves silt, granules, and cuttings from the mud of the drilling well using vibration.

It's the last day of the Muslim holy month of Ramadan, and the cafeteria menu stars *haleem*, a staple at this time of the year in Hyderabad. There is also a typical Andhra meal of chicken curry, rice, pulses and vegetables. The workforce sitting in the cafeteria hardly looks up as their boss enters. Reddy leads us into a private room, plays the good host and casually converses with his top team. "I run a very democratic organisation, and I like people going about their work. No one looks at me when I walk in," he says.

Reddy points out how (and why) MEIL acquired Drillmec. This Italian company makes rigs for the oil and natural gas industry, and its acquisition gave MEIL's business an edge. His optimism on India's technological

prowess is clear, and he believes no country "can beat us on that, hard work, involvement and talent".

He says his message to the team is: build your project the way you would build your home, with the same attention to quality and finishing. "I have the same commitment and lead by example." A diffident Reddy is not comfortable taking questions on electoral bonds. "I became visible only because of the recent developments," he says with half a smile. MEIL's political contacts cut across parties—it also made electoral bond contributions to the DMK, YSR Congress Party, Telugu Desam Party and the Indian National Congress.

Dodging the subject of bonds, Reddy says his biggest skill is high-quality execution within timelines. "The Zoji-la project is 50% done, and we are very happy with the progress. You must look at our factories in India and worldwide to understand our execution skills and the employment we generate," he says. He rolls off locations in Odisha, Kerala, J&K, Mexico, and Brazil, where projects are underway, the factories in Houston in the US, Milan in Italy, Zambia, Mongolia, Russia, Rwanda and the Middle East or a factory he once owned in Belarus. "We don't work like a typical contractor. One must understand that water, refineries, thermal power, hydel, solar, transmis-